



DAY-FIGHTER FAILURE

The two-seater Messerschmitt Bf 110 was a failure as an escort fighter in the Battle of Britain, but a resounding success as a night interceptor, playing a leading role in the defense of Germany.

and bomb-aimers to home in on. The main bomber force followed in behind the pathfinders in a “bomber stream” that hopefully would overwhelm the German defenses by sheer numbers. By the end of 1943, bombers had VHF radio for air-to-air communication, so that a pathfinder “master bomber,” circling the target during the attack, could direct the operations.

German defenses

But none of these technical improvements could give the RAF air superiority in the night skies over Germany. A chain of radar stations denied the

bombers any chance of surprise. Night fighters stood ready to scramble from their airfields and intercept the attackers from whichever direction they came. Potential targets were surrounded by a dense barrier of searchlights and defended by radar-directed anti-aircraft guns. It was no wonder that Bomber Command losses remained high.

Early in the war, German night fighters, guided toward the bombers by ground controllers, had to rely on their eyesight to close in for the kill. The introduction of the Lichtenstein airborne interceptor radar (see page 242) greatly improved their effectiveness, even if the strange assembly of direction-finding antennae attached to the fighter’s nose – dubbed the “barbed wire fence” by German pilots – produced drag that slowed the aircraft down. Later still, the Germans were equipped with infrared detectors that could pick up on a Lancaster’s engine exhausts.

Until mid-1943 the German night fighters were committed to a rigidly planned sector defense, staying within “boxes” under strict ground control. During the crisis of the Battle of Hamburg, however, more flexible tactics began to be adopted.

Pilot Hajo Herrmann

pioneered what became known as *Wilde Sau* (“Wild Boar”) tactics, in which single-seat day fighters roamed freely over the target area at high altitude, swooping down on bombers they spotted silhouetted against ground fires. This was so successful that special *Wilde Sau* squadrons were established. After *Wilde Sau* came *Zahme Sau* (“Tame Boar”), in which night fighters with onboard radar shadowed or mixed with the bomber stream, picking off targets at will.

Single-seat fighters like the Bf 109, used by *Wilde Sau* squadrons, were not equipped for night fighting. Most night operations were entrusted to two-seater Bf 110s or converted bombers such as the Ju 88. These aircraft had the crew to operate the radio and radar equipment that made night flying reasonably safe and effective, and were fast and nimble enough to take on unescorted bombers.

The deadly battle of wits in the night war brought both complex technical advances and inspired improvisations. For example, to exploit the fact that RAF bombers had no gun under the fuselage, some German Bf 110s were equipped with two upward-firing cannon, known rather bizarrely as *Schräge Musik* – a slang term for jazz. The interceptor positioned itself in level flight underneath a bomber and, using a reflex sight for aiming, fired directly upward, ideally trying to hit the fuel tanks. The RAF never really found an

AIRCRAFT RECOGNITION

Luftwaffe recruits use models to learn to identify German and Allied aircraft. Airmen on both sides suffered from “friendly fire” when misidentified by anti-aircraft gunners or fellow fliers.

